SOCIO-ECONOMIC IMPACT OF THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC ON OECD COUNTRIES

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ABSTRACT

The study aims to study the socio-economic features of the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on the economic systems of the OECD countries, as well as to analyze the measures taken by states for their subsequent adaptation in the economies affected by the crisis. The authors identified the OECD countries with the highest number of cases of coronavirus, which demonstrated positive dynamics of socio-economic indicators after a significant recession due to the pandemic (USA, France, Germany, Italy, Great Britain, Spain). The article analyzes the dynamics of key socio-economic indicators that characterize the development of the OECD countries under study in 2020 compared to the same period in 2019 (unemployment rate, inflation rate, gross national savings, exports and imports of goods and services). The measures implemented by states to stabilize economic activity and maintain social well-being during the pandemic are studied. The authors concluded that the economic and social measures taken by the OECD countries under study are common and that the results of their implementation differ significantly. It is proved that Germany is the country that has most successfully implemented a package of anti-crisis measures based on an effective monetary policy and direct state support for the real sector, which allowed it to maintain the volume of export–import operations and gross savings at the pre-crisis level, prevent an inflationary jump in the country and not exacerbate the problems with increasing unemployment. Germany's experience in creating a basis for

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overcoming the global economic crisis can be adapted to the conditions of the countries most affected by the pandemic.

Keywords: OECD countries; pandemic; crisis; recession; unemployment; inflation; public policy

JEL Classifications: F62; F63; F68

In the context of the formation of the new world order, the turbulence and instability of socio-economic development increase dramatically. It is accompanied not only by new challenges and threats but also by the avalanche formation of new realities, contradictions and conflicts. Thus, the characteristic features of the recent development of the global economy are structural changes in labour productivity and the slowdown in economic growth in various countries of the world, despite the emergence of new digital tools to stimulate it (European Commission, 2019; Karpunina & Lyubimenko, 2020; Weforum, 2019). The imbalances in world trade caused by the trade wars between the United States and China, the increasing level of protectionism, as well as the growing political and economic problems in the European Union associated with Brexit have formed the conditions for the development of another global economic crisis (Portansky, Sudakova, & Larionov, 2020).

The uneasy situation in the global economy has been overlaid by the outbreak of the pandemic, which has a fundamentally different impact on individual citizens, businesses, nation-states and the entire global economy. The sudden destabilization of the epidemiological situation in the world, a prolonged lockdown and a catastrophic decline in economic activity led to a sharp decline in economic growth, the suspension of international cooperation and cooperation, the destruction of economic ties and the launch of recessionary processes (Erokhina & Dzhergenia, 2020; Karpunina, Zabelina, Galieva, Melyakova, & Melnikova, 2020; Lisova, Petrov, Koryakina, Kalombo Mulamba, & Karpunina, 2020; McKibbin & Fernando, 2020; Mejokh, Korolyuk, Sozaeva, Pilipchuk, & Karpunina, 2020). During the pandemic, countries took various socio-economic and political measures that determined the speed of their economies' recovery from the crisis and the success of their adaptation to the new economic conditions (Drobot, 2020; Phan & Narayan, 2020).

However, countries with traditionally developed economies are not always able to overcome the conditions of uncertainty in a short time. Often, the choice of one's behaviour model and clear step-by-step implementation of stabilization measures make it possible to overcome the recession in the economy most successfully and maintain social well-being. The study of the implemented measures and the assessment of their effectiveness in overcoming the crisis phenomena provoked by the COVID-19 pandemic is currently extremely relevant, first of all, for countries trapped in the economic and epidemiological crisis.

THE THEORETICAL BASIS OF THE STUDY

The causes, nature and dynamics of economic crises are presented in the studies of the founders of the theory of crises Marx, Veblen, Mendelson, Khinshtein, Freeman, Kondratiev and Leontiev. Scientists have linked the causes of economic crises with over-production, the imbalance of monetary relations, the imperfection of the banking sector and its impact on the economy, cyclical nature of economic development. In the scientific literature, there are different views on the causes of the current crisis phenomena in the economy; some of them are reflected in the works Yakovets (2004), Budanov (2018), Efimov (2017), Stepashkina (2019).

Since the beginning of 2020, the new object of economic research has been the COVID-19 pandemic and its impact on various sectors of the economy and public life, identifying the dynamics of development and assessing the consequences. Karpunina et al. (2020), Mejokh et al. (2020), Erokhina and Dzhergenia (2020), Lisova et al. (2020) show how epidemiological threats affect the economic security of an independent state and its territorial units. McKibbin and Fernando (2020), Drobot, Makarov, Nazarenko, and Manasyan (2020) consider the global macroeconomic impact of the pandemic. An important area of modern research is the study of measures implemented by states to overcome the pandemic for the economy and society. In this context, the works of Salisu (2020), Drobot et al. (2020), AliMaer, Moon, & Jiha (2020), Baker (2020), Baldwin and Weder di Mauro (2020), Berg (2020), Cochrane (2020), Liu (2020), Nicola (2020) are of interest. They are aimed at finding effective tools for managing various sectors of the economy to reduce recessionary manifestations.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

The study aims to reveal the socio-economic features of the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic on the economic systems of the OECD countries, as well as to assess the effectiveness of the measures taken by states for their subsequent adaptation in the economies affected by the crisis.

Research objectives: (1) identify the OECD countries that have demonstrated positive dynamics of socio-economic indicators after a significant recession due to the pandemic; (2) identify the OECD countries with the highest number of coronavirus cases; (3) analyze the stabilization measures implemented by states and the resulting dynamics of socio-economic indicators during the pandemic.

Research methods: the method of theoretical analysis, the method of economic and statistical analysis, the method of comparative analysis, the graphical method, the system approach.

For the analysis, the authors used the IMF's World Economic Outlook database, which contains separate sets of macroeconomic data and the IMF's forecasts for economic development at the country and global levels. In addition, the authors used the statistical materials of the OECD, Gisanddata.

RESULTS

The dynamics of the gross domestic product calculated by the expenditure method in the OECD countries in 2020, quarterly, seasonally adjusted, is presented in Table 1.

The data allow us to identify several OECD countries that had a significant drop in GDP in Q2 2020 compared to Q1 2020 but provided GDP growth in Q3 2020. The positive dynamics of quarterly GDP allows us to conclude the effectiveness of measures taken by state bodies to counteract the negative consequences of COVID-19. For example, the outsider countries in terms of GDP decline in Q2 2020 relative to Q1 2020 (India (−25.2%), Great Britain (−18.8%) and Spain (−17.9%)) showed growth in Q3 2020 relative to Q2 2020: +21.9, +16% and +16.4%, respectively. China became the leader in growth rates (+11.6%); other countries showed a slight decline in GDP in Q2 2020 compared to Q1 2020 (Korea (−3.2%), Ireland (−3.2%). These countries also managed to achieve GDP growth in Q3 2020 compared to Q2 2020: China (+3%), Korea (+3%), Ireland (+11.1%).

The top 10 countries in the world by the number of cases of coronavirus diseases based on official statistics on COVID-19 is presented in Table 2.

Further analysis requires the formation of a list of the countries studied from among the economically developed countries that are in the top 10 countries in terms of the number of cases of diseases and except for the most severely affected by COVID-19 developing countries (India, Brazil, Russia and Turkey). Thus, our research interest will focus on the study of the behaviour during the pandemic of the following countries: the United States, France, Great Britain, Spain, Italy and Germany.

In the analyzed countries, the main tool for overcoming the negative consequences of the pandemic and solving the problems of increasing global risks is the implementation of an effective monetary policy and the provision of direct government support to the markets. Monetary policy is primarily aimed at stimulating demand and ensuring the growth of the global economy, and only then – at directly supporting financial institutions in the form of active support for the liquidity of the financial and banking system and ensuring the stability of exchange rates. For example, the central banks of the analyzed countries quickly responded to the crisis by reducing key rates – the US Federal Reserve reduced the key rate range to a minimum of 0–0. 25%, most central banks in developed countries also decreased key rates to historical lows. As additional measures, the central banks have expanded banks' access to existing liquidity provision mechanisms (repo operations) by increasing the terms, limits and easing the requirements for collateral accepted in the framework of refinancing operations. The central banks of the countries studied also lowered reserve requirements to release additional liquidity (Federal Reserve: to zero from 10% for liabilities above a certain amount and 3% for liabilities below a certain amount).

The regulatory authorities of the analyzed countries have launched new lending support programmes against the background of a loss of liquidity, aimed at maintaining financial stability. Thus, the United States has launched nine

Table 1. Gross Domestic Product – Expenditure Approach, Growth Rate Compared to the Previous Quarter, Seasonally Adjusted, Quarterly, %.

Country	Q1 2020	Q2 2020	Q3 2020	Q4 2020
China	−9.7	11.6	3.0	2.6
Korea	−1.3	−3.2	2.1	1.1
Ireland	−3.5	−3.2	11.1	–
Russia	−0.9	−3.2	1.5	–
Finland	−1.5	−3.9	3.2	–
Norway	−1.5	−4.7	4.6	–
Saudi Arabia	−1.3	−5.2	1.8	–
Estonia	−0.8	−5.5	3.3	–
Lithuania	−0.0	−5.9	3.8	1.2
G20	−3.4	−6.6	8.1	–
Indonesia	−0.7	−6.9	3.0	2.9
Australia	−0.3	−7.0	3.3	–
Switzerland	−1.7	−7.0	7.2	–
Denmark	−1.5	−7.1	5.2	–
Latvia	−2.3	−7.1	7.1	1.1
Iceland	−7.6	−7.3	2.6	–
Luxembourg	−1.5	−7.4	9.8	–
Sweden	0.3	−8.0	4.9	0.5
Japan	−0.5	−8.3	5.3	–
Slovak Republic	−5.1	−8.3	11.6	–
Israel	−1.7	−8.5	8.7	–
Czech Republic	−3.3	−8.5	6.9	0.3
Netherlands	−1.5	−8.5	7.8	–
United States	−1.3	−9.0	7.5	1.0
Poland	−0.3	−9.0	7.9	–
Brazil	−1.5	−9.6	7.7	–
Germany	−2.0	−9.7	8.5	0.1
Slovenia	−4.7	−9.8	12.4	–
NAFTA	−1.3	−10.0	8.0	1.3
Bulgaria	0.4	−10.1	4.3	–
G7	−2.1	−10.4	9.3	–
OECD – Total	−1.9	−10.5	9.2	–
Turkey	0.2	−10.8	15.6	–
New Zealand	−1.2	−11.0	14.0	–
Canada	−1.9	−11.3	8.9	1.9
European Union – 27 countries	−3.3	−11.4	11.5	−0.5
Austria	−2.8	−11.6	12.0	−4.3
Belgium	−3.4	−11.8	11.6	0.2
Romania	0.0	−12.2	5.8	–
Italy	−5.5	−13.0	16.0	−2.0
Chile	3.0	−13.5	5.2	–
France	−5.9	−13.7	18.5	−1.3

Table 1. *(Continued)*

Country	Q1 2020	Q2 2020	Q3 2020	Q4 2020
Portugal	−4.0	−13.9	13.3	0.4
Greece	0.1	−14.1	2.3	–
Hungary	−0.4	−14.6	11.4	–
Argentina	−4.1	−16.0	12.8	–
Colombia	−1.4	−16.1	8.7	–
South Africa	−0.4	−16.6	13.5	–
Mexico	−1.2	−17.0	12.1	3.1
Spain	−5.3	−17.9	16.4	0.4
United Kingdom	−3.0	−18.8	16.0	–
India	0.7	−25.2	21.9	–

Source: Compiled by the authors based on OECD (2020).

credit programmes, including supporting money market investment funds, lending to municipalities, supporting lending to SMEs and consumers. In the face of the continuing unfavourable economic environment, US regulators have adjusted their programmes to support lending to SMEs. The United Kingdom has implemented preferential lending programmes for banks that increase lending to SMEs. Leading central banks have significantly expanded their asset purchase programmes, and the Federal Reserve has begun to buy back Treasury securities and mortgage-backed securities in the amount necessary to ensure the smooth functioning of the market and the effectiveness of the monetary policy transmission mechanism. The European Central Bank has launched an asset purchase programme (government and corporate securities) in the unprecedented amount of 750 billion euros (in June 2020, expanding it to 1.35 trillion euros). The volume of the asset purchase programme was also increased by the Bank of England. Coordinated actions by central banks were taken to support dollar liquidity in the global market.

Table 2. Top 10 Countries in the World by the Number of Cases of Coronavirus.

	Country	The Total Number of COVID-19 Diseases as of 17 February, 2021, People
1	USA	27,756,737
2	India	10,937,320
3	Brazil	9,921,981
4	Great Britain	4,070,332
5	Russia	4,066,164
6	France	3,548,452
7	Spain	3,096,343
8	Italy	2,739,591
9	Turkey	2,602,034
10	Germany	2,354,927

Source: Compiled by the authors based on Gisanddata (2021).

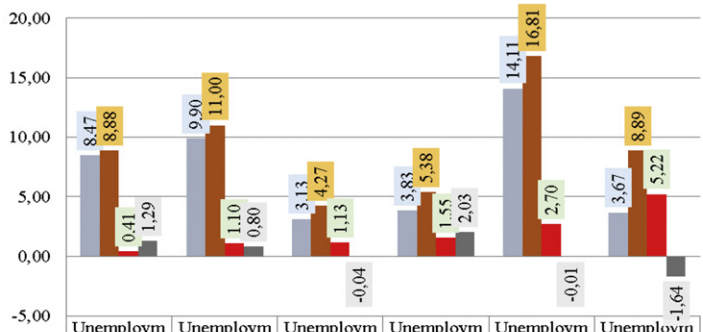
In addition, the regulators implemented a policy of easing financial regulation and introduced some temporary regulatory eases to buy time and smooth out the negative effects of the crisis on the real sector and the financial system. Temporary easing and countercyclical measures within the framework of the implemented macro-prudential policy were aimed at supporting lending to the economy, including through the use of buffers. For example, German banks were allowed to postpone the recognition of bad loans due to the pandemic. This has become a necessary counter-measure to avoid the risk of a negative spiral of loss of access to credit, leading to an additional decline in the economy and damage to the financial sector. In the United States, restructured loans of affected borrowers are temporarily allowed not to be classified as problem debt. The European Central Bank has stopped classifying loans with a state guarantee as problem loans. Also, in many of the countries studied, recommendations were issued to banks on restructuring the debt of companies (primarily SMEs) and households. Many regulators extended the duration of credit vacation programmes in the fall of 2020 to avoid massive insolvency cases. For example, the extension of credit holidays in various forms was implemented in the United Kingdom and Spain. In general, this measure was implemented for a short time, but in the United Kingdom it was decided to re-extend the credit holidays for some categories of borrowers until 31 January 2021.

An effective tool for supporting the economies of the analyzed countries was the implementation of a policy of budgetary and extra-budgetary incentives – income support and ensuring credit growth. The main measures include: (1) government loan guarantees (Italy, Germany, France, United Kingdom); (2) special government business support programmes (grants to small and medium-sized enterprises, targeted support for healthcare, airlines) (Italy, Germany, France, United Kingdom, USA); (3) direct social benefits to the population: subsidies for salary payments (United Kingdom), increased unemployment benefits (USA), easing of requirements for unemployment benefits (Germany, Italy, France, Spain), direct one-time payment of money to the population (USA); (4) various tax breaks (tax holidays for individuals and businesses with deferred tax payments for 90 days in the United States; deferred tax payments in Spain, France).

The global economic crisis, the lockdown and the resulting sharp decline in business activity, despite vigorous government measures to preserve employment, have affected the growth of unemployment. The analysis of the dynamics of unemployment in the analyzed countries for 2019–2020, based on the IMF forecast, is shown in Fig. 1.

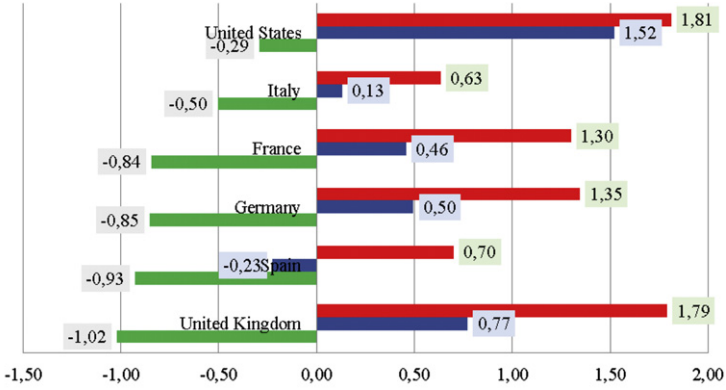
The graph shows that the negative trend of unemployment growth in 2020 is typical for all the analyzed countries. The highest growth in unemployment is observed in the United States (+5.22%). The unemployment rate in Spain (+2.7%), the United Kingdom (+1.55%), Germany (+1.13%) and Italy (+1.10%) increased significantly. The minimum increase in unemployment is typical for France (+0.41%).

The decline in business activity and the response measures to maintain the purchasing power of citizens led to a decrease in the level of consumer prices for all goods (Fig. 2).



	Unemployment rate France	Unemployment rate Italy	Unemployment rate Germany	Unemployment rate United Kingdom	Unemployment rate Spain	Unemployment rate United States
2019	8,47	9,90	3,13	3,83	14,11	3,67
2020	8,88	11,00	4,27	5,38	16,81	8,89
2020-2019	0,41	1,10	1,13	1,55	2,70	5,22
2021 (Forecast)-2020	1,29	0,80	-0,04	2,03	-0,01	-1,64

Fig. 1. The Unemployment Rate in the USA, France, Italy, Germany, Great Britain, Spain, %, 2019–2020. *Source:* Compiled by the authors based on International Monetary Fund (2020).



	United Kingdom	Spain	Germany	France	Italy	United States
2019	1,79	0,70	1,35	1,30	0,63	1,81
2020	0,77	-0,23	0,50	0,46	0,13	1,52
2020-2019	-1,02	-0,93	-0,85	-0,84	-0,50	-0,29

Fig. 2. Inflation Rate in the USA, France, Italy, Germany, Great Britain, Spain, %, 2019–2020. *Source:* Compiled by the authors based on International Monetary Fund (2020).

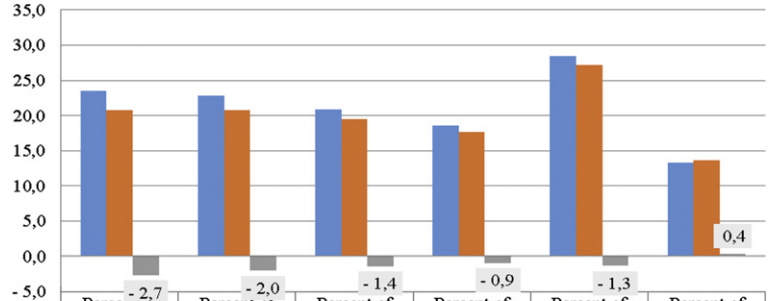
According to the IMF, the maximum decline in inflation in 2020 compared to 2019 occurred in the United Kingdom (−1.02%), Spain (−0.93%), Germany (−0.85%), France (−0.84%), Italy (−0.50%), and the minimum decline is typical for the United States (−0.29%).

The negative impact of the coronavirus pandemic, which manifests itself in the form of falling household incomes, has negatively affected gross national savings (as the ratio of gross national savings in current local currency to GDP in current local currency). The calculation of this indicator, based on the IMF data for 2019–2020, is shown in Fig. 3.

The dynamics of gross savings according to the IMF in 2019–2020 shows that the maximum decline in gross savings occurred in France (−2.7%), in Spain; it was −2%, in Italy (−1.4%), in Germany (−1.3%) and in the United States (−0.9%). The United Kingdom managed to increase gross savings by 0.4%.

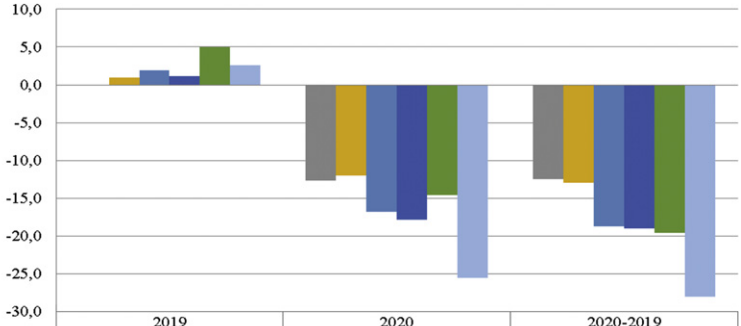
The global lockdown had the strongest impact on the established foreign economic relations and, accordingly, the dynamics of the volume of exports of goods and services for 2020 (Fig. 4).

Analysis of changes in exports of goods and services suggests that the pandemic has caused enormous damage to export operations. The maximum decrease in annual export growth for 2020 compared to 2019 was achieved in Spain (−28.1%), the United Kingdom (−19.6%), Italy (−19%), France (−18.7%), Germany (−13%) and the United States (−12.5%). Imports of goods and services also declined significantly. The annual dynamics of the volume of imports of goods and services for 2020 and 2019 according to the IMF is shown in Fig. 5.



	Percent of GDP Gross national savings France	Percent of GDP Gross national savings Spain	Percent of GDP Gross national savings Italy	Percent of GDP Gross national savings United States	Percent of GDP Gross national savings Germany	Percent of GDP Gross national savings United Kingdom
2019	23,5	22,8	20,9	18,6	28,5	13,3
2020	20,8	20,8	19,5	17,7	27,1	13,7
2020-2019	- 2,7	- 2,0	- 1,4	- 0,9	- 1,3	0,4

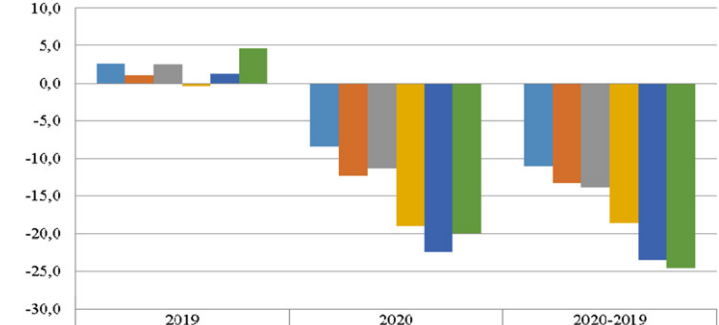
Fig. 3. Gross National Savings in the USA, France, Italy, Germany, Great Britain, Spain, % of GDP, 2019–2020. *Source:* Compiled by the authors based on International Monetary Fund (2020).



	2019	2020	2020-2019
United States	-0,1	-12,6	-12,5
Germany	1,0	-12,0	-13,0
France	1,9	-16,8	-18,7
Italy	1,2	-17,8	-19,0
United Kingdom	5,0	-14,6	-19,6
Spain	2,6	-25,5	-28,1

Fig. 4. Exports of Goods and Services to the USA, France, Italy, Germany, Great Britain, Spain, 2020, in % Compared to the Same Period in 2019. *Source:* Compiled by the authors based on International Monetary Fund (2020).

The maximum decrease in imports of goods and services according to the IMF occurred in the United Kingdom (−24.6%), Spain (−23.6%), Italy (−18.6%), France (−13.9%), the United States (−13.4%) and the minimum decrease is typical for Germany (−11%).



	2019	2020	2020-2019
Germany	2,6	-8,4	-11,0
United States	1,1	-12,3	-13,4
France	2,5	-11,4	-13,9
Italy	-0,4	-19,0	-18,6
Spain	1,2	-22,3	-23,6
United Kingdom	4,6	-20,0	-24,6

Fig. 5. Imports of Goods and Services in the USA, France, Italy, Germany, Great Britain, Spain, 2020, in % Compared to the Same Period in 2019. *Source:* Compiled by the authors based on International Monetary Fund (2020).

CONCLUSION

The authors identified the OECD countries with positive dynamics of socio-economic indicators after a significant recession due to the pandemic: the United States, France, Germany, Italy, Great Britain and Spain. The analysis of socio-economic indicators that characterize the dynamics of the development of the studied countries during the pandemic (the level of unemployment, the level of inflation, gross national savings, exports and imports of goods and services) allowed the authors to conclude the different level of effectiveness of the implemented state policy. It is proved that despite the commonality of the anti-crisis measures taken by the OECD countries under study, the final results of their implementation are highly differentiated. The measures of monetary policy and direct government support for the real sector implemented in Germany showed the greatest effectiveness. This suggests that it is possible to adapt the positive experience of Germany in overcoming the crisis phenomena for other countries affected by the pandemic.

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